DERECH HASHEM: THE RAMHAL'S WAY OF GOD, AT TIFERET EYAL

What Can Yom Kippur Atone For?

Derech Hashem 4:8:5-6, 4:9:1

Sefer: Derech Hashem by Rabbi Moshe Hayim Luzzatto (the Ramhal) **Section:** Part 4, Chapter 8, paragraphs 5-6, and Chapter 9, paragraph 1 **Shiur:** Part of Dayan Daniel Kada's Derech Hashem series at Tiferet Eyal, Monday 9 May 2022

These notes are based on an automatic transcript of the recording.

Recap: Rosh Hashanah in one sentence

The class has been going through the seasonal misvot: Shabbat, Pesah, Sukkot and the lulav, Hanukkah and Purim, and last time Rosh Hashanah. Asked to sum it up, a participant said: it is not about asking for things. The Rabbi refined this: it is not wrong to ask, but it misses the point. Once we reveal Yihud Hashem and crown God through the shofar, moving Him from the chair of judgment to the chair of mercy, everything else falls into place. "You're focusing on the source."

Yom Kippur (paragraph 5)

God gave Israel one day on which repentance is more easily accepted and sins more easily forgiven: a day to repair all the spiritual damage caused by sin, remove the darkness sin brings into the world, and return the penitent to the holiness and closeness he had before he sinned.

The Rabbi stressed that teshuvah works any day. If it is sincere and genuine and goes through the stages of teshuvah, you can do it tonight and it will work. Yom Kippur makes it easier.

A participant raised a question: if Yom Kippur only returns a person to where he was, what about the Gemara in Berakhot that in the place where baalei teshuvah stand, even the completely righteous cannot stand, and that their sins become merits? The Rabbi said this was an excellent question he had also asked himself. His possible answer: the Gemara speaks of someone who has changed his whole lifestyle, his very identity; here the Ramhal speaks of repairing particular sins, which brings a person back to his former level.

What Yom Kippur does and does not cover

The Rabbi set out four levels of sin:

1. Missing a positive misvah, such as not putting on tefillin or saying Shema too late. This is a lost opportunity; in Temple times one could bring an olah, a kind of apology, but there is no punishment.
2. A negative prohibition carrying lashes, such as deliberately eating pork. Sincere teshuvah removes it at once; Yom Kippur is not needed.

3. Sins carrying karet or the death penalty, such as deliberately breaking Shabbat. Teshuvah does half the work, and Yom Kippur completes it.
4. Hillul Hashem, for which even Yom Kippur is not enough.

And all of this applies only to sins between a person and God. For sins against other people, Yom Kippur does nothing without putting things right with them. "So people don't think Yom Kippur is everything." It is truly needed only for a fraction of sins, though in practice Yom Kippur inspires us to think about all the sins we have not yet repented.

Becoming like angels

To receive the light of the day, one must keep its laws: the melakhot as on Shabbat, and the five afflictions: no eating or drinking, no washing, no anointing, no leather shoes, no marital relations. Their purpose is to separate us from our physical identity and raise us to the level of angels.

That is why on Yom Kippur we wear a tallit at night and say Barukh Shem aloud: "because we are no longer the same humans which we are during the year." And this is how we come into the light of teshuvah.

Reading the Torah (paragraph 6)

One of the great institutions of the prophets was the public reading of the Torah, in two forms:

1. Reading the whole Torah in a fixed cycle, whether every year or every three years. "It doesn't matter how often, the point is you would have a cycle."
2. Reading special portions on the festivals, relevant to each day.

As learned earlier in Part 4, even simply reading the words of Torah brings down its light and inspires a person. That is something each of us does privately; the prophets also instituted that the Torah be read publicly, in order, so that the community constantly has its light. And on the festivals, reading the relevant section strengthens the light of the day. The Torah is "the strongest power": you can observe Pesah and talk about it, "but there's nothing like reading from the Torah about the festival."

So there are three kinds: private study, the public cycle, and the festival readings.

A participant questioned whether the prophets instituted this, recalling that the Gemara says Moshe instituted the reading after the people went three days without water. The Rabbi agreed: Moshe instituted reading every three days, Ezra added Shabbat afternoon and fixed Mondays and Thursdays, and the festival readings came from Hazal. The Ramhal's word "prophets" must refer to Moshe together with the development by Ezra, the whole process of the reading of the Torah.

The last chapter: circumstantial misvot (Chapter 9, paragraph 1)

The class began the final, short chapter of Derech Hashem, started a year and a half earlier. The fourth category of misvot is circumstantial: you do not have to do these things, but if you do them, this is how. If you have a house, a mezuzah and a parapet. If you bake bread, take hallah. If you want to eat meat, slaughter the animal. If you have an employee, pay him on

time. The Rabbi noted that most of the misvot in the Torah are of this kind. Sisit too, at its core, is circumstantial, applying only to a four-cornered garment, though today we have made it daily.

The Ramhal explains that these misvot cover how we live in this world: our food, our clothes, all our necessities, and our dealings with one another. Food: terumot and maaserot, if you own a field in Israel. Clothes: shaatnez and sisit. Our homes: mezuzah and a parapet. Our relationships: all the misvot between man and his fellow.

Why? As learned at the beginning of the book, nothing in the universe exists without serving the purpose of creation: that God bestows good on us and we come close to Him. Everything has a spiritual root above and is reflected below. So we were given commandments in all these areas, to place them on the good side. When we act within the Torah's framework, good and rectification flow through them. Everything physical can be elevated or degraded, depending on how we use it. We must eat to live, but the misvot let our eating become service of God.

This applies on every level of creation: the inanimate (mezuzah, parapet), plants (kilayim, terumot and maaserot, leket, shikhehah, peah, Shemittah, lulav), animals (the prohibition of causing them pain, korbanot, the Pesah offering) and human beings.

A participant asked: if failing to do a positive misvah is only a lost opportunity, why does the Ramhal imply that without it things end up on the bad side? The Rabbi called it an excellent question and answered from what was learned before: this world naturally sinks if left static. Not acting is a lost opportunity, and because the opportunity was lost, the thing is naturally pulled down. The class plans to finish the chapter and the book on Thursday.

Summary

- Rosh Hashanah is about crowning God and moving Him to mercy; Yom Kippur makes repentance easier and returns a person to his former closeness.
- Teshuvah alone clears many sins; Yom Kippur is needed for karet and capital sins, does not cover Hillul Hashem, and does nothing for sins against others until they are put right.
- The five afflictions lift us to the level of angels, which is why we wear a tallit at night and say Barukh Shem aloud.
- Public Torah reading, in a cycle and on festivals, brings down the Torah's light and strengthens each festival's light.
- Circumstantial misvot elevate every area of physical life, from objects and plants to animals and people.

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